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Instantly Improve Your Yellow Pages Ads, Coupons & Sales Letters

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....We begin with a little workshop on Yellow Pages ads. Whether you're a YP advertiser or not, there's much to be gained from studying this media - because it is THE most competitive advertising arena of all....

IF YOU THOUGHT ALL WINDOWS WERE CREATED EQUAL.

Hey, this is a very solid direct-response ad. The headline is good, all four subheads even better. The little arrows tying the illustration to the copy make you want to read the copy. Copy's good, too. A benefit in just about every little block of copy. Bold facing and caps used well. The "50 years" indecia for some credibility. Too bad the free estimate offer wasn't more prominent...plus a free info offer. But compare it to the ad right next to it - both the same size - and see which one really SELLS! You can bet your bottom dollar that the YP Rep whined and moaned about all the tiny print in this ad.

WARNING: DO NOT BORROW MONEY.....

A classic "warning" ad.
It WILL be read by every person hitting this page. And it is well-written. It delivers a simple, easy to understand "differential argument" ie. them vs. us, and why we are better. A winner.

**WHY GO TO THE CLEANERS?
WE'LL PICK IT UP FROM YOU.**

Solid ad - good enough to work in other media. As a postcard. In biz-to-biz Val-Pak. Etc. Daily pick-up and monthly billing...both strong benefits. And look: an offer!!! - 25% off first order. Mild waste of space showing the darned logo in two places.

NEED STOOLS NOW?

If I'm going into the YP looking for stools, this ad's got it. The headline slanted at the side grabs the prospect's attention. Other headline's good too: AREA'S LARGEST SELECTION. The words "in stock" are important, as is "immediate delivery." Winston Churchill said: "if you want me to give a good hour-long speech, I'll need a few minutes to prepare; if you want me to give a good five minute speech, I'll need a few days to prepare." It's hard to deliver a strong message in a few words. They got it done here.
(From September 1994 Issue)

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Featured How-To Article:

MAKING MONEY WITH DIRECT-MAIL: HOW BOB & ART, THE CARPET CLEANERS, DO IT

Well, inspite of the USPS' mess, and inspite of all the new, "hot", high tech media, Direct-Mail continues to INCREASE in useage as the #1 favored means of marketing in America. So, in this Issue, I've decided to give you a little "seminar" on making money with direct-mail.

Two of our IC Members are rapidly becoming "master practioners" and demonstrate exactly how direct-mail can be used effectively to grow a small business.

Here's their letter to me (5/27/94): "Dear Dan: I'm writing to let you know how we are doing with our 'get new customers' campaign. You will recall that we started out with 2,350 names in an affluent neighborhood compiled from a street directory.* We decided to send 800 postcards as a test. (From Postcard#1) 5 people called and placed orders - a 0.625% response. Initially, I was a little disappointed. I was hoping for 1%. However, the size of their orders** was such that we actually made a small profit, so we mailed the rest of the list. I was delighted with the unexpected higher response of 0.85%.

"We have done direct-mail in various formats before. I've gotten higher response rates. *** But this mailing ferreted out more customers that will become repeat buyers.*** How do I know? Because they fit our profile of those who buy frequently -- monied, large homes with lots of wall-to-wall carpeting, and they have children or pets to quickly resoil their carpeting.

"What we haven't done before, what your newsletter inspired us to try, is sequential mailings to the same list.**** *What would happen if we closely followed up with another mailer?* A couple of weeks later we mailed another 765 postcards (800 less respondents, less nixies) - Postcard #2, to the test portion of our list. We immediately got 4 more calls. 2 were inquiries our secretary could not sell, 1 ordered but called back and cancelled but the 4th turned out to be a good new customer. A few days later, 2 more called - both real nice jobs. Then another person - who got both postcards, saw our truck at her neighbor's house***** and came over after we left to inspect our work - then called.

"The response rate to Postcard #2 sent to the test portion of our list is about 0.5% or about break-even. Overall, we got 22 new customers and made a couple hundred dollars to boot." (2,300 targeted prospects; 22 customers; 2 sequential postcards) ******

Now, everybody's going to want to see these postcards but there is much more important subject matter here. Consider my asterisked (*) items:

* Bob used a carefully compiled, target list. He did NOT take the lazy ways out of just mailing a zip code or a rented list. He did some compilation work. Get this: as reluctant as we pro, highly paid, egotistical copywriters are to admit it, grudgingly I'll tell you, Gary Halbert'll tell you, John Carleton'll

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tell you, Ted Nicholas'll tell you: the quality, the appropriateness of the list has at least as much (probably more) to do with a direct-mail campaign than does the 'creative' ie. the copy, the graphics and the format. In fact, in a hierarchy of importance, in most cases, I'd rank it this way:

#1: LIST
#2: OFFER
#3: COPY
#4: OTHER CREATIVE

This is a very important Principle, talked about in "the books" much less than it deserves. That's why, to digress, in business-to-business marketing, it pays to call and verify the correct name and title of the most appropriate decision-maker/recipient in each targeted company rather than mailing to "Vice-President, Sales." That's why it pays to do Lead Generation Advertising (with a Lead Generation Magnet), to get the "hottest" possible names. Etc. Investment in list quality and appropriateness is a wise investment.

** We do NOT put response percentages in the bank. We put DOLLARS in the bank. Measure return-on-investment, not response percentages! It is very easy to get sucked into conversations about comparative response percentages even though they do not matter at all. Quite often, direct-mail for new customer acquisition is going to come in below 2%, over half the time below 1%, and that, if looked at out of context, can be very discouraging to people. Yet, that 1/2-0f-1% response rate can translate into a reliable System for building a business with zero customer acquisition cost. And there should be THE goal for most small businesses and sales careers: how can we add new customers to our business without expense in getting them?

***Use targeted direct-mail to get the EXACT (kind of) customers you want most. You do NOT have to settle for "bodies". For anybody and everybody. Nor should you. There MUST be a certain "profile" of the customer/client/patient who is perfectly matched with your products, services, prices, personality, etc. Look, there's clearly a market for Subway sandwiches; it's the 2nd largest fast food chain in the world. But there are also "deli purists" who would rather starve than eat a Subway, and there are delis who can best take care of these customers.

****This is, by far, one of the most important Marketing Systems that I teach and use. If you are a new subscriber, refer to THE MAGNETIC MARKETING SYSTEM KIT, 1994 EDITION. (1-800-223-7180.) Please get this, once and for all: do NOT waste your money doing one-shot mailings. They rarely work even well enough to break even. Yet the residual influence of Mailing #1 added to a 2nd, 3rd, etc. Mailing to that same list WILL make money. There is so much "behind" the structures I teach for sequential mailings that I could spend a day just explaining them.

Note the term "residual influence." After a mailing, when, say, 2 out of 100 have responded, there is a "residual influence" left...another 2, 3, 5, 10, maybe more who ALMOST responded. They came very, very close. They read the letter. Set it aside. Read it again a couple days later. Stuck it up on the frig with a Mighty Morphins magnet. There it gathered dust for a week. Saturday morning it got noticed and thought about again. Maybe she even got as far as the phone. But, ultimately, it got tossed out. These people who ALMOST

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responded WILL respond to another nudge or two -- if the nudges come quickly enough to capitalize on the residual influence.

*****"Multi-Media Reinforcement" - one media helps another work. For example, this kind of targeted, solo DM could help a Val-Pak/Money Mailer effort in the same area and it would help the solo DM. Driving the truck up and down these streets a few times the week before the mail drop would help the mailing. Etc.

******Have realistic expectations for new customer acquisition. The most successful advertising/marketing will deliver new customers to most kinds of businesses at break even (zero acquisition cost) to slight profits. The real profits must come from TCV; Total Customer Value...repeat business, referrals. Be dedicated to Maximum TCV in your business.

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A DOZEN QUICK THOUGHTS ABOUT DIRECT-MAIL COUPONS

I'm sitting here with a Val-Pak, a Money Mailer,and an AdVo package, and I've carefully gone through all three. if you study the ones that come to you, you'll find a number of repeat advertisers and a number of advertisers who use all of these media...which tells you that they are getting results. The other thing you'll notice is that most coupons look the same. In fact, in this Val-Pak, there are THREE pizza place coupons - all virtually identical and interchangeable. I believe in these coupon programs for many types of businesses, and pass along this summary of my ideas about them:

1. Even with "ordinary", lookalike coupons, many businesses can get break even or better results from this media consistently, repeatedly and frequently.

2. The media works best for "common" businesses that people already, instantly understand, periodically need and use, and, often, are price driven. Fast food, carpet cleaning, auto painting, dentistry, hair salons.

3. This is a "cheap" media to test in, and most will let you split test two different coupons within the same zone. So, once you have a "control"; a coupon that works consistently and repeatedly, you can start testing against it.

4. Most coupons can be dramatically improved just by creating and using a strong, compelling headline.

5. The "rules" for Yellow Pages ads and postcards apply to these coupons.

6. Photos often help, especially a story that shows a story and has a caption that is a second headline.

7. Against your control, some things to test: print the back...do the front like an "ad", the back like a letter; try an 'advertorial' format. Discuss putting in non-coupon formats...full pages, four page brochures, newsprint tear sheets, etc. "Get outside the box!"

8. Consider testing this media for businesses and offers not usually advertised here. Steven Present (and several copycats) use Val-Pak and an 11x17" 4 page brochure to very successfully fill the $39.95 seats at his stop smoking/weight loss seminars. For marketers to small businesses, remember that, with the explosion of home-based businesses, the demarkation between 'consumer media' and 'business media' is blurring

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rapidly. In the Val-Pak I have here, a COPYBOY copy/print shop inserted an 8-1/2x11" sheet, with six coupons on one side; a calendar on the other, with a different special offer on every day of the month's calendar. I notice that the shop has extended, consumer oriented hours, and a 'new business start-up package' as one of its offers. They have aimed this at small/home-based businesses.

9. Very, very, very, very few coupons use second choice, free recorded message numbers, offer Widgets, etc. (per my Magnetic Marketing Systems.) All these things work here!

10. Ask for first-time advertiser and test discounts, free color, other concessions for testing, split-testing, buying more than one zone, etc. - most of these are independent franchisees; get to the franchise owner and negotiate. Educate the franchisee about stand-by and remnant rates.

11. How about joint venture advertising in this media? Maybe a chiropractor, dentist, optometrist, etc. could go together on an 11x17 insert, half filled with helpful health information from each, the other half, their coupons. Create something with enough informational value it might be kept and used. How about all the stores in one strip center or little shopping center going in together one on insert in this media?

12. There are "national advertiser programs" for these media, and national mail-order advertisers do use them.

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WHAT COMES BEFORE THIS!!??!!

of how totally committed he was to: using Courier type for the body copy of his sales letters, with right side ragged (not justified like this), a typewritten letter look. Then RENE GNAM, one of the top direct-mail wunderkinds around, reported a test where the letter done in Courier pulled a whopping 54% better than the typeset version. Proves Ted's right, right? Wrong, old Assumption Breath!

In another test, Rene got a 14% better response with typeset body copy vs. Courier. Just what we needed: more confusion. But here's the point: you just cannot be truthful and be dogmatic about this field. When you hear guys like Ted, Gary, even me give you "rules", you'd better believe we have biases built in, and often out of necessity in a seminar, book or tape, we're being overly simplistic and giving the most-likely-to-succeed-most-often prescription. But such dogma IS dangerous. Different strategies work better in different situations, with different markets. That's why we TEST.

So how do you get through this confusion? Most often, I will try to establish a "control" that adheres to the most-likely-to-succeed dogma, and that delivers satisfactory results. Then, once that is working, you can test one variable at a time against your own control. Of course, this requires an on-going campaign with sufficient numbers that you can keep segmenting and testing. In cases where it's a one-shot mailing to a repetitively used list (something I do a lot), I'll usually go with the "rules" rather than against them. But I've often achieved some spectacular results by breaking rules left and right.

Putting together a direct marketing 'system' takes commitment. Right now, I have a client wrestling with all this - he's got a campaign working at a minimal level, just barely breaking even, but with enormous potential. He has to be incredibly patient as he tests one variable at a time, against this weak control, until he gets the right mix of list, offer and presentation. But when he does, he'll own a unique money-machine good for years and years, capable of producing millions of dollars of profit.

(Sources: Rene Gnam, 1 Response Rd., Tarpon Springs, Fla./ and The What's Working Newsletter/and Ted Nicholas.)

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HOW TO TURN AN ORDINARY BUSINESS INTO AN EXTRA-ORDINARY ONE: OUR ADVERTISING EXAMPLE OF THE MONTH

BOY, DID YOU MISS A GREAT SEMINAR END OF APRIL, AT OUR LAST MILLIONAIRE-MAKER DAY. We had about 40 really terrific, bright, progressive folks...we did 'hot seats' that were really instructive...we had a terrific time. One of the attendees, Joe Polish, is taking the most innovative, use-every-method-possible approach to the carpet cleaning business...**heck, his business card alone is a seminar in itself - to wit:**

(Front)

FIBERTECH Professional
Carpet & Upholstery Cleaning

Every Job Guaranteed.
You pay only if you're pleased.

Call WE-CLEAN
602/932-5326

(Inside - 2 Panels)

HOW YOU CAN ENJOY A FRESH, CLEAN, HEALTHY CARPET.

If all you want is a cheap, brush off the dirt cleaning, then we respectfully ask that you call another carpet cleaner. But if you want to protect your health - if you want to protect your family from the countless bacteria, fungus, pollens, pollutants and tobacco smoke residue in your carpet, then you're invited to call us. We'll answer your questions and give you a free written estimate without cost or obligation of any kind.

FREE CONSUMER
AWARENESS MESSAGE:
235-2121

Call now and listen to our free Consumer Awareness Message. You'll discover 6 costly misconceptions about carpet cleaning, 7 questions to ask a carpet cleaner before you invite him into your home. Plus we'll offer 4 recommendations about how you can enjoy a fresh, clean, healthy carpet. To hear this free, informative message, call 235-2121.

FREE CONSUMERS GUIDE
TO CARPET CLEANING.
CALL 932-5326.

In this fact-filled booklet, you'll discover how to.....

...then there's a whole list of bullet points and a closing call to action.

(Back)

WHAT YOU SHOULD KNOW
ABOUT FIBERTECH -
A MESSAGE FROM THE OWNER.

...here there are four compelling reasons to do business with Joe...an expanded USP.

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All right, for starters, don't call and bother Joe about this. You're smart enough not to need to steal every word he's written; I've given you plenty right here.

Next: "Fit all that on a business card? Who'll read all that? The type's too small?" - friend, I hear that foolishness all the time from people with their heads stuck firmly in the sand. Arguing against what he's doing is like arguing against flight.

Incidentally, I tore the head off of one guy at Millionaire-Maker Day, maybe a little more brutally than I should have. But he started to play the game of responding to suggestion after suggestion of proven strategies by telling me "I tried that and it doesn't work." Unfortunately, that's just one of those really asinine responses that sets me off. The truthful response can only be "I tried that but I loused it up so badly it didn't work for me, even though it works for thousands of people just like me, in my business. Help!" But that's not what he said. Too bad; he might have learned something. Anyway, you cannot argue with Joe's success with Fibertech; I know his numbers and they are phenomenal.

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HOW TO CREATE DIRECT-MAIL PACKAGES THAT GET OPENED AND READ

``A-Pile Mail`` is not the only way to go. YOU HOPEFULLY STUDY ``BOARDROOM REPORTS'' DIRECT-MAIL.....the #10 envelopes covered, I mean COVERED with teaser copy - like: What Never To Eat On An Airplane, page 17....What Your Banker Prays You'll Never Find Out, page 38...etc. The sales letters used by Boardroom to sell their newsletters and books rely heavily, and very, very successfully on this single approach - the idea of someone not wanting you to know something...of a conspiracy keeping secrets from you. The creator of all this for Boardroom, Mel Martin, died in Febuary, at age 70. During his copywriting career, over 100-Million envelopes and letters went out with his copy on them. Here are some of the tantalizing, provocative bullet points from Boardroom's current, Mel Martin ``control'' (promoting their Bottom Line Newsletter):

- Cruise ship rapes: the uncensored facts which even the news media won't touch
- The little-known casinos that offer the best odds
- Get a hotel suite...while paying for a room!
- This letter is about information that's ``none of your business''
- Conventional wisdom: you can't push an insurance company when it comes to collecting money. Wrong! There are two proven ways to get your check within days.
- How to outwit a mugger in a self-service elevator. (One of the worst big city traps.)
- How to spot an honest auto mechanic.
- Eight things to leave out of a job resume.